SPIRITUAL/RELIGIOUS FALSE BELIEF #2 · GOD

“God loves me only when I perform well.”

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Where it often comes from

Parents or caretakers whose love and approval seemed to depend on good grades, good behavior, or success. A church culture that measured faith by attendance, service, giving, or how much you did. Being praised for what you did rather than for who you are. Perfectionism that spilled over into how you think God sees you.

What Scripture teaches

God’s love is not a reward for good behavior. He loved you before you did anything right, and Christ died for you while you were still a sinner. Salvation is a gift, not a wage. Prayer, Bible reading, and service are ways of responding to His love, not ways of earning it. On your worst day, God’s love for you in Christ is exactly the same as on your best.

> *“For it is by grace you have been saved, through faith—and this is not from yourselves, it is the gift of God—not by works, so that no one can boast”* **(Ephesians 2:8–9)**.

Also see

> “But God demonstrates his own love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us” **(Romans 5:8)**.

> “This is love: not that we loved God, but that he loved us and sent his Son as an atoning sacrifice for our sins” **(1 John 4:10)**.

> “He saved us, not because of righteous things we had done, but because of his mercy” **(Titus 3:5)**.

> “For I am convinced that neither death nor life, neither angels nor demons, neither the present nor the future, nor any powers, neither height nor depth, nor anything else in all creation, will be able to separate us from the love of God that is in Christ Jesus our Lord” **(Romans 8:38–39)**.

Common self-statements

- If I don’t pray or read my Bible enough, God loves me less.
- I have to keep serving to stay in God’s good graces.
- When I fail, I lose God’s love until I make up for it.
- Other Christians do more than I do, so God must prefer them.
- I can never rest; there is always more I should be doing for God.
- God is pleased with me only when I get it right.

Common logical errors

- **Conditional worth:** Believing that you are loved only when you perform well, as if love were a paycheck.
- **All-or-nothing thinking:** Judging yourself as either a “good Christian” or a total failure, with nothing in between.

- **Should statements:** Living by rules such as “I should pray an hour a day” and feeling unloved when you miss.
- **Comparison:** Measuring God’s love for you by how your spiritual life looks next to other people’s.
- **Disqualifying the positive:** Dismissing the times God has been good to you when you had done nothing to earn it.
- **Emotional reasoning:** Concluding “I don’t feel close to God today, so He must love me less.”

Challenging questions

- Where did I learn that love has to be earned? Does that make it true of God?
- Did Christ die for me after I got my life together, or while I was still a sinner?
- If salvation is a gift, how could I earn it, and how could I lose it by having a bad week?
- Am I confusing God’s love with my feelings about God on a given day?
- What would change if I served God out of thankfulness instead of fear?
- Would I tell a struggling friend that God loves them less on their bad days?

Truth summary

> God’s love for me is not a reward for my performance. He loved me while I was still a sinner and sent His Son to die for me. My salvation is a gift of grace, not a wage I earn. Nothing I do or fail to do can separate me from His love in Christ. I serve Him because I am loved, not so that I will be loved.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Grace
- Love, By God
- Salvation
- Christ, Sacrifice Of
- Self-Esteem, Low
- Thinking, Unhealthy

Each morning ask: “If I truly believed God’s truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?”

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "God loves me only when I perform well"

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Read through each section and **check the one that fits you best**. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ **Date started:** _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"God loves me only when I perform well." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Did Christ die for me before or after I got it right?
- ☐ Who taught me that love has to be earned?
- ☐ If salvation is a gift, how could I earn or lose it by my performance?
- ☐ Am I confusing God's love with how I feel today?
- ☐ Am I serving God out of fear or out of thankfulness?
- ☐ Would I tell a friend that God loves them less on bad days?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ God loved me before I did anything right.
- ☐ God's love is a gift, not a paycheck.
- ☐ My performance does not change God's love for me.
- ☐ Nothing can separate me from the love of God in Christ.
- ☐ I serve God because I am loved, not to be loved.
- ☐ On my worst day, God's love for me is the same as on my best.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- [ ] **Ephesians 2:8–9**
  "For it is by grace you have been saved, through faith—and this is not from yourselves, it is the gift of God—not by works, so that no one can boast."
- [ ] **Romans 5:8**
  "But God demonstrates his own love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us."
- [ ] **1 John 4:10**
  "This is love: not that we loved God, but that he loved us and sent his Son as an atoning sacrifice for our sins."
- [ ] **Titus 3:5**
  "He saved us, not because of righteous things we had done, but because of his mercy."
- [ ] **Romans 8:38–39**
  "For I am convinced that neither death nor life, neither angels nor demons, neither the present nor the future, nor any powers, neither height nor depth, nor anything else in all creation, will be able to separate us from the love of God that is in Christ Jesus our Lord."

A verse I found myself: _____

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first three. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ **Make my Truth Card** (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ **Memorize my Scripture** from Step 4.
- ☐ **Set reminders** to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ **A buzz:** my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ **An everyday event:** every time I _____
  - ☐ **A visual reminder:** something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ **Evidence log:** Each day, write down one good gift from God that I did nothing to earn.
- ☐ **My name in Scripture:** Rewrite my verse with my name in it and read it aloud each morning.
  *For example, Romans 5:8 becomes: "But God demonstrates his own love for **Sarah** in this: While **Sarah** was still a sinner, Christ died for **her**."*
- ☐ **Gratitude journal:** Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ **Truth recording:** Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ **Reading:** The "Grace" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ **Listening:** The Overcoming Depression audio download.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

- ☐ **Take a guilt-free rest.** Set aside 30 minutes to rest without doing anything "productive," and notice that God's love does not change.
- ☐ **Pray for five minutes just to say thank you,** with no requests and no checklist, for three days in a row.
- ☐ **Skip one "extra" church duty** you took on out of guilt, and notice what you feel and what actually happens.
- ☐ **Live "as if" for one day:** act the way a person who believes God's love is a free gift would act.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "God loves me only when I perform well": _____ % **My truth:** _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	An unearned gift from God today
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~God loves me only when I perform well.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, help me reject the lie that Your love depends on how well I perform. Thank You that You loved me while I was still a sinner and that my salvation is a gift of Your grace. Free me from striving to earn what You have already given, and let my service flow from thankfulness. In Jesus' name, Amen.

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